

How to Create and Set Up a Google Merchant Center Account (2026)

2927 words · draft generated Aug 05, 2026, 10:03 AM UTC

A Google Merchant Center account is the foundation everything else in Google Shopping sits on. Without one, a Shopify or WooCommerce catalog cannot appear in Shopping ads, free product listings, or the Shopping tab, no matter how well-optimized the catalog itself is. For any ecommerce merchant, digital marketing agency, or PPC manager running paid or organic Shopping campaigns in 2026, setting up a Google Merchant Center Account correctly is non-negotiable groundwork, not an optional technical detail. It's also one of the areas where a small, avoidable mistake early on can quietly stall a campaign for days before anyone notices why.

This guide is a complete Google Merchant Center setup 2026 walkthrough, covering both halves of the job. The first half is the one-time setup: creating the account, verifying the business, configuring shipping and tax, connecting a product feed, and submitting for Google's review. The second half is the ongoing guidelines Google expects every merchant to keep following after approval. Most guides skip this part entirely, even though a Merchant Center account can be suspended just as easily, and often just as unexpectedly, as it was approved in the first place.

Treat this as a definitive reference, not a beginner's overview. Each step below reflects exactly what Google's own setup flow requires today, and each guideline reflects a real, common reason accounts get flagged, not a generic best practice. Ecommerce teams running Shopping campaigns at any scale will find the same underlying requirements apply. That's true whether the account is set up once by an in-house marketer, or configured repeatedly by a PPC team onboarding new clients across a portfolio of dozens of accounts.

Simple Steps for Setting Up Google Merchant Center

Getting a store ready to sell on Google Shopping breaks down into seven concrete steps. None of them is optional: Google's review process checks for all seven before approving Shopping ads or free listings, whether this is the first time a team has had to set up a Google Merchant Center account or the tenth.

1. Create the account itself.
2. Add contact and business information.
3. Verify and claim the store's website.

4. Configure shipping and sales tax.
5. Connect a product feed.
6. Review Google's policies.
7. Submit the account for review.

The sections below walk through each one in order, roughly matching the sequence in Google's own setup flow, so a merchant or PPC manager working through this for the first time can follow it top to bottom without jumping between different help articles.

Step 1: Create A Google Merchant Center Account

1. Go to merchants.google.com and sign in with an existing Google account, or create one dedicated to the business. Many agencies prefer a separate Google account per client rather than reusing a personal one.
2. Click "Get started" and accept the Merchant Center Terms of Service.
3. Select the business's country and time zone. This choice determines which Shopping policies, tax rules, and supported payment methods apply to the account going forward, and it can't always be changed later without creating a new account.

This is genuinely how to create Google Merchant Center account access from a completely blank start. There's no separate "developer" or "business" tier to choose between at this stage, just the one account type.

Step 2: Adding Contact Information and Business Information

Next, Google asks for several pieces of business information:

- Business name
- Website URL
- Registered business address
- Phone number
- Customer service contact details

This isn't just internal record-keeping for Google. Several of these fields, particularly the business name and customer service contact, can surface directly on Shopping ads and free listings that shoppers see, and inconsistencies here are a routine cause of avoidable review delays. Getting this Google Merchant account setup step wrong, even something as small as an inconsistent business name, can trigger a policy flag later when Google cross-checks it against the live storefront. A store that trades as "Acme" on its homepage but registers as "Acme Trading LLC" in Merchant Center is a common example. It's worth entering this information exactly as it appears on the website itself, rather than a shortened, legal, or marketing-friendly version, and double-checking it against the site's own footer or contact page before submitting.

Step 3: Need to verify your store website

Before Google will associate any products with a domain, the account must claim and verify that website. Google offers several verification methods:

- Adding an HTML meta tag to the site's homepage
- Linking an existing Google Analytics account
- Linking an existing Google Tag Manager account
- Verifying through Google Search Console

Any one of these confirms genuine ownership of the merchant center account's target domain. This requirement exists for a straightforward reason: without it, anyone could list products under a domain they don't actually control, which would make Google Shopping useless as a trustworthy source of product listings. Agencies managing multiple client stores should verify each domain separately, even when several stores share infrastructure.

Step 4: Setting Up Shipping And Sales Tax

Shipping and tax settings are configured next, and products cannot go live in Shopping ads until both are set up. For shipping, merchants can choose:

- A flat rate per region
- Carrier-calculated rates pulled live from a shipping provider
- A combination of both, along with estimated delivery times shoppers see before clicking through

Sales tax settings vary considerably by country. Many US-based merchants set tax rates manually per state, since US pricing is typically shown tax-exclusive, while merchants in regions with tax-inclusive pricing norms can rely on their listed price directly.

Getting this wrong doesn't just risk a policy issue: inaccurate shipping costs or tax handling are a common reason shoppers abandon checkout after clicking a Shopping ad.

Ways to add products to Google Merchant Center:

There are several real ways to get products into a Google Merchant account, and most stores beyond a handful of SKUs won't be adding them one at a time:

- Manual single-product entry through the Merchant Center interface
- A one-time bulk upload via spreadsheet
- A scheduled fetch that pulls an updated feed file from a hosted URL on a set schedule
- The Content API, for stores with large or frequently changing catalogs that need programmatic control

- Platform integrations, such as a Shopify or WooCommerce feed app, that generate and sync the feed automatically

In practice, most ecommerce sellers running an active catalog use a feed-based method rather than manual entry, since it keeps pricing, availability, and stock levels accurate without ongoing manual work.

Steps to add a primary feed:

1. Go to the Products section in Merchant Center and select Feeds, then click to add a new feed.
2. Choose the destination: Shopping ads, free listings, or both. This affects which fields Google expects.
3. Select an input method matching how the feed will be maintained. A scheduled fetch from a hosted feed URL is the most common choice for stores using a feed-generating app, though a one-time upload or the Content API both remain options.
4. Give the feed a clear, identifiable name, especially important for agencies managing several feeds across accounts.
5. Set the fetch schedule so product data, including price, availability, and stock, stays current automatically rather than requiring a manual re-upload every time something changes.

Step 6: Review Google Policies

Before submitting the account for review, it's worth reading through Google's Shopping ads and Merchant Center policies directly rather than assuming the setup so far is compliant. Key areas to double-check:

- Product data accuracy: titles, prices, and availability matching the live site exactly, down to the currency and any active sale pricing
- No prohibited or restricted content anywhere in the catalog
- Working destination URLs that lead directly to the specific product being advertised, not a category page, a search results page, or an out-of-stock notice

It's worth spot-checking a random sample of listings against the live site rather than assuming the feed is accurate end to end. This step is easy to skip since it doesn't involve any new configuration, but it's the single step that prevents the most common and entirely avoidable cause of an early rejection.

Step 7: Submit Your Merchant Centre for Review

Once the account, product feed, shipping, and tax settings are all in place, the account can be submitted for Google's review. This review typically takes a few business days, though it can occasionally take longer during high-volume periods, and the current status is always visible directly in the Merchant Center dashboard rather than requiring

a separate status check. Agencies managing client accounts should set expectations accordingly: a client asking why Shopping ads aren't live yet a day after setup is a common, avoidable conversation.

If a submission is rejected, the most common reasons are:

- An unverified or unclaimed website
- A policy violation somewhere in the product data
- Incomplete business information from Step 2

All three are worth checking against before resubmitting, since a second avoidable rejection extends the delay further and can draw additional scrutiny to the account.

Follow the Guidelines of the Google Merchant Centre

Getting an account approved is genuinely only the beginning. Compliance with Google's guidelines is ongoing, not a one-time checkbox, and a previously approved Merchant Center account can be suspended just as easily as a new one can be rejected, often for the same underlying reasons, sometimes months after everything appeared to be running smoothly. An account that passed review cleanly can still lose Shopping visibility overnight if a pricing mismatch creeps in, a checkout page loses its SSL certificate during a site migration, or the account simply goes quiet for too long. The guidelines below cover exactly what Google expects a merchant to keep maintaining after launch, worth treating as a standing checklist revisited periodically, not a one-time read before submission.

Google Merchant Center guidelines

The following eight guidelines are the practical rules Google expects every merchant to maintain continuously, not requirements that are satisfied once during setup and then forgotten. Each one reflects a real, common reason accounts get suspended, drawn from the same categories Google's own policy documentation flags most often, and each is straightforward to audit periodically. Building this into a recurring account-health check, ideally alongside the regular feed updates already happening, is far easier than only revisiting it after a suspension notice arrives. For agencies managing several client accounts, a shared checklist covering these eight points across every account is a small process investment that avoids a much larger cleanup later.

Follow Shopping Ads policies

Beyond the general Merchant Center policies, Shopping ads specifically require:

- Pricing and availability shown in the ad match the landing page exactly
- Destination links work and lead directly to the advertised product

- Product data meets Google's editorial and content requirements: clear, accurate titles and descriptions without promotional filler like "best," "free shipping," or excessive punctuation stuffed into the title field

A mismatch between what an ad shows and what a shopper actually finds on arrival, such as a sale price in the ad that's expired on the site, or a product shown as in stock that's actually sold out, is one of the most consistently enforced Shopping ads policies. It's also one of the easiest to catch with a routine spot-check of live ads against the current site.

Avoid prohibited practices

Certain practices will get a Merchant Center account flagged regardless of how well everything else is configured:

- Misleading claims about a product's features, effects, or origin
- Counterfeit or unauthorized replica goods of any kind
- Clickbait-style product titles designed to inflate clicks rather than describe the item honestly
- Keyword stuffing in titles or descriptions, such as repeating a target term multiple times or appending unrelated popular search terms to manipulate search ranking

These are consistently among the most common and most avoidable causes of suspension, since they're rarely accidental and usually traceable to a specific listing practice, often introduced by a well-meaning attempt to improve visibility, that's straightforward to correct once identified.

Don't sell restricted products (or follow restrictions)

Some product categories are outright banned from Google Shopping, while others are restricted and only allowed under specific conditions.

- Banned, with essentially no exceptions: weapons and weapon accessories, tobacco and related products, counterfeit or replica goods
- Restricted, requiring specific certifications, regional licensing, or disclaimers before they can be listed legally: certain health and medical claims, supplements, financial products

Any merchant selling in a gray-area category should check Google's restricted products list directly before listing, rather than assuming a product is allowed simply because a competitor is currently listing something similar. That competitor's listing may itself be in violation and simply not yet caught.

Only promote products available for direct purchase

Every product listed must be something a shopper can actually buy directly from the linked landing page: the exact item shown in the ad, in the specified size, color, or variant, not a similar item or a related product from the same collection. Listing an out-of-stock item without correctly updating its availability status violates this guideline. So does sending shoppers to a landing page where the advertised product isn't actually purchasable, whether that's a discontinued item, a sold-out variant, or a page that redirects to a generic category. This is a common issue for stores with frequent stock turnover or seasonal inventory, which is exactly why an automated, regularly updated feed matters more than a one-time manual upload. Stale availability data is one of the fastest ways to accumulate policy violations without anyone noticing.

Use a supported language consistently

Product titles and descriptions must be written in a language Google supports for the account's target country, and that language needs to stay consistent throughout the entire feed rather than mixing languages within a single listing or shifting inconsistently across the catalog. This matters most for merchants selling internationally with country-specific Merchant Center configurations. A feed accidentally mixing languages, often from a partial translation, a machine-translated batch that was never reviewed, or a copy-pasted template left over from a different market, can cause otherwise well-optimized listings to be disapproved even though the underlying product data is accurate. Agencies running feeds across multiple country targets should treat each language version as its own quality check, not a single pass applied everywhere.

Collect user information securely

Any part of the buying process that collects user information, including checkout, account creation, newsletter sign-up, and saved payment details, needs to meet a few real requirements:

- HTTPS with a valid, unexpired SSL certificate
- A clear, accessible privacy policy
- Secure payment processing

Google checks for this as part of its broader trustworthiness requirements for merchants, and it's not a one-time check. Certificates expire, and a site migration or hosting change can quietly drop HTTPS enforcement on a single checkout page without breaking the rest of the site. This is worth including in the same periodic review as the feed itself.

Sign in regularly

Google expects some baseline of ongoing account activity, and an account left completely dormant for an extended period can be automatically flagged or suspended, even if every other setting remains technically compliant and the feed is still updating

correctly in the background. This applies even once a Merchant Center account is running smoothly with a fully automated feed. It's precisely the accounts that feel "set and forget" that are most likely to go unchecked long enough to trigger this. A regular sign-in, even just to glance at account health and any policy notices, is worth treating as routine maintenance on the same cadence as a monthly campaign review, not something only needed during active setup or when something visibly breaks.

Disclose AI-generated titles/descriptions

Note: One of the newer and less widely known requirements heading into the current Google Merchant Center setup 2026 guidelines concerns AI-generated content. Where product titles or descriptions have been generated, or substantially rewritten, by AI tools rather than a human, merchants should be prepared to disclose this according to Google's current guidance rather than presenting AI-assisted copy as entirely human-written. This is a genuinely evolving area of policy rather than a settled rule, and specifics around exactly how and where disclosure needs to appear have shifted as Google refines its approach. It's worth checking Google's latest Merchant Center help documentation directly before relying on AI-generated copy at scale across a large catalog, rather than assuming a policy read months ago still reflects current enforcement, since this is one of the areas most likely to change again.

Conclusion

Setting up a Google Merchant Center Account correctly is what makes Shopping ads and free listings possible at all, but as the guidelines above make clear, setup is only half the job. The account creation, verification, shipping and tax configuration, and feed setup covered in the first half of this guide are one-time tasks. The eight guidelines that follow are a continuous responsibility that doesn't end once an account is approved, and never really goes away for as long as the account stays active. Treating compliance as ongoing, rather than something to revisit only after a suspension notice arrives, is what separates merchants with stable, consistently visible Shopping campaigns from those who lose visibility right when a campaign is finally performing well.

The stakes here are real. A suspended Merchant Center account doesn't just pause Shopping ads temporarily: it can take a business's entire paid and free Shopping presence offline while the issue gets identified and resolved, often at real cost to a campaign that was otherwise working exactly as intended. For ecommerce merchants and the agencies managing their accounts, keeping a Google merchant account accurate, compliant, and consistently updated is worth building into a regular process, such as a monthly or quarterly review, rather than treating it as a one-time setup task that's finished once the account goes live.

Keeping a product feed accurate and policy-compliant without manual upkeep is exactly the kind of ongoing work that's easy to fall behind on when it's handled by hand. Simprosyst's Google Shopping Feed app handles feed generation and syncing

automatically, so pricing, availability, and product data stay current without needing to revisit the Merchant Center dashboard every time something changes in the store.